

Birds

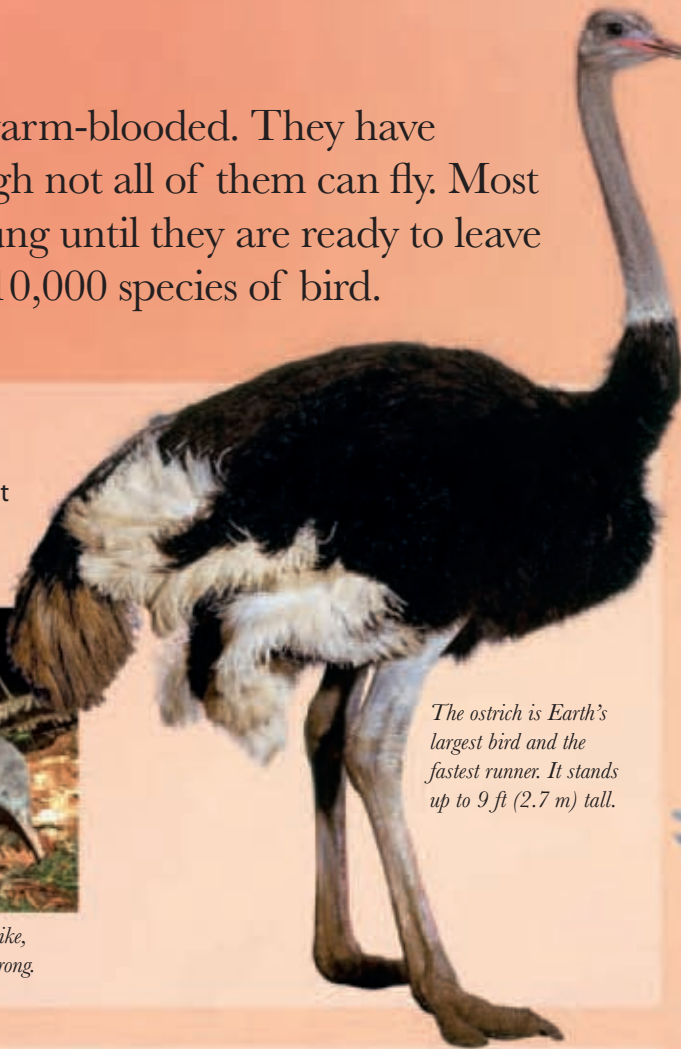
Unlike reptiles, birds are warm-blooded. They have wings and feathers, although not all of them can fly. Most birds take care of their young until they are ready to leave the nest. There are about 10,000 species of bird.

Ratites

With weak wing muscles and flat breast bones, ratites cannot fly. They escape danger by running away.



Kiwis are the smallest ratites. Their plumage is hairlike, their bills are long, and their sense of smell is very strong.



The ostrich is Earth's largest bird and the fastest runner. It stands up to 9 ft (2.7 m) tall.

Fowl and waterfowl

Fowl are chickenlike birds with strong legs and feet. They fly well over short distances, although they spend most of their lives on the ground. Waterfowl usually have webbed feet. They are good swimmers and feed in water or on land.



Male ducks, such as this mandarin, are often brightly colored, which helps them to attract a mate.



A swan can fly at more than 30 mph (50 kph), but to get its heavy body airborne involves running and flapping.



The male peafowl, or peacock, will erect his fan of extravagant tail feathers to attract peahens during courtship.

Male grouse have showy courtship rituals. In this dance, the females prefer the males that rest the least.



New birds

All birds other than ratites, waterfowl, and fowl belong to a huge group that scientists call Neoaves, or "new birds," because they appear recently in the fossil record. All of these birds have powerful wing muscles and most are completely at home in the air. The largest flyers include albatrosses, storks, and pelicans, but the most varied are small songbirds, or passerines. These make up about one-third of all bird species.



Albatrosses soar on outstretched, narrow wings. One tracked bird traveled 3,700 miles (6,000 km) in 12 days.



Gulls live in large, noisy groups along coasts and inland waterways and some scavenge on human garbage.



All hummingbirds weigh less than 1 oz (24 g) and some beat their wings up to 200 times a second during courtship.



Birds of paradise live in tropical forests. Males have spectacular plumage and elaborate courtship displays.